

A blurred background image of a modern office interior. In the foreground, a woman with dark hair tied back, wearing a blue blazer, is seated at a long wooden table, working on a laptop and holding a pen. Other people are visible in the background, also working at tables. The office has a high ceiling with exposed ductwork and modern lighting.

Colliers U.S. Copy Style Guide

The Purpose of this Guide

Everything we do and write contributes to Colliers' reputation. Grammatical and style errors diminish our credibility and professionalism. This can lead to tangible, negative outcomes – editors could reject our media releases, our proposals for new business might be unsuccessful, or readers might misunderstand what we mean. Conversely, cleanly edited, accurate and succinctly compelling content helps readers immediately understand, engage and respond effectively to our messages while contributing to Colliers brand success.

We have put together the following guidelines to help ensure that all internal and external communications are on brand and consistent in the market. For a comprehensive reference library to help you communicate successfully, follow this guide for work in the U.S. and Colliers' global style guide for international communications or where a question arises that is not covered by the U.S. guide.

Keep this guide handy as a grammar, punctuation and style reference to help you write consistently in the Colliers voice.

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Quick Tips

Colliers' Possessive Form

The correct possessive form of Colliers.

- ✓ Colliers'
- ✗ Collier's

Advisor vs. Adviser

- ✓ advisor
- ✗ adviser

Square Feet Abbreviation

- ✓ sq. ft.
- ✗ sq. ft or sq ft
- ✓ SF (for charts, advertising, bulleted lists or incomplete sentences)

Job Title Capitalization

Capitalize job titles only when they immediately precede a name.

- ✓ Jane Smith, managing director
- ✓ Vice President Stan Jones
- ✓ Three vice presidents visited.

Business Lines and Team Names

Business lines and team names are capitalized.

- ✓ Roberts Debt Advisory Group
- ✓ Klein Valuation Team

Services and Sectors

Unless part of a team name, services and sectors should not be capitalized in a sentence.

- ✓ We provide tenant representation across retail, office and industrial sectors.

Bulleted Lists Capitalization

Do not use title case or all caps. Use sentence case, even with phrases.

- ✓ Sentence case is readable.
- ✗ Capital Letters in Every Word
- ✗ ALL CAPS

Dates and Numbers

Do not use *nth*, *rd*, *st* or *th* in a date.

- ✓ June 21, 2019
- ✓ June 21 (no year)
- ✗ June 21st, 2009

Company Names

Professional abbreviations such as LLC, Plc., Ltd., etc. should be removed from client lists.

- ✓ Construction Company
- ✗ Construction Company, LLC

Internet Terms Hyphenation

- ✓ email / online / website
- ✗ e-mail / on-line / web-site

And vs. Ampersand (&)

The word "and" should be written as an "&" in service lines.

- ✓ Engineering & Design
- ✗ Engineering and Design

Nationalities and Languages

Nationalities and languages are title case only.

- ✓ He was German.
- ✓ He spoke Spanish.

British English Spellings

Some spellings and word choices differ in Canada and other parts of the world. Use U.S. English in the U.S.

- ✓ color / zip code
- ✗ colour / postal code

Million and Billion

Spell out the words million or billion in copy. Abbreviate to M and B for tables and headlines.

- ✓ \$500 million / \$500B
- ✗ \$500 bn / \$500,000,000,000

Numbers Usage

One to nine are written in full. Numbers 10 and over are written numerically.

- ✓ one / two / three / 10 / 11 / 12
- ✗ 1 / 2 / 3 / ten / eleven / twelve



Spelling

Each region and/or country has specified standard journalism style guides or dictionaries to follow for consistency. U.S. content creators should refer to the current Associated Press (AP) [Stylebook](#) for information not presented in this guide. Bear in mind that the printed AP Stylebook is updated every other year, and the digital version is updated throughout the year.

Make sure your Microsoft Office dictionary is set to the appropriate language. [Find out how.](#)

Note: Refer to the Global Colliers Guide for British English and metric examples.



Important Company Terminology

The following terminology represents Colliers’ approved word choice to describe our business. For more information on groups, asset classes, industries and services we provide, please visit colliers.com/en/services.

Colliers: Legal Name	Colliers International Group Inc. (No comma in legal name)	
Colliers: Official Written Name	Colliers is the official written name for use in all instances, except where its legal name is required. Do not abbreviate as CI or Colliers International.	☒ I work for Colliers ☐ I work for CI ☐ I work for Colliers International
Colliers: Possessive Case	Never place an apostrophe within the word Colliers. An apostrophe may appear after the final “s” to denote possessive use.	☒ Colliers, Colliers’ values ☐ Collier’s
Colliers: Teams, Divisions, Offices	Our divisions, teams or offices are not businesses in their own right. Therefore, in longer content, we should not refer to Colliers Irvine or Colliers Retail. Use only when there is limited space, such as in a tight newsletter blurb.	☒ Our team in Los Angeles, or the Colliers team in Boston For limited space only: ☒ Colliers Sydney ☒ Colliers Phoenix’s John Jones

Department Names	Capitalize division and department names when using them as proper titles. Do not capitalize in general use.	✔ Corporate Solutions specialists serve the needs of corporate tenants.
	Where and forms part of the department name, it should be written as &, not and.	✔ Industrial & Logistics ✔ Valuation & Advisory ✘ Industrial and Logistics
	The words “department” and “team” are always lower case.	✔ Our Research & Forecasting department provides expert advice.
Hub	The Colliers intranet is called the Hub, and the H is always uppercased.	✔ The U.S. Hub is located at https://colliers.sharepoint.com/sites/us
Services	Services that are also department names should always be lower case and never written with an & in lists of services.	✔ We provide agency advice across the main retail, office, industrial and logistics sectors.
		✘ We provide agency advice across main Retail, Office and Industrial & Logistics sectors.
Web address	Our web address should always be written as colliers.com. The www. is not required. /en autopopulates when you type colliers.com.	✔ colliers.com ✘ www.colliers.com

Common Industry Terminology

WORD	RULE	EXAMPLES
A		
about or approximate 1. about 2. approximately 3. approx.	Be concise by using about. Where possible, write out the full word. It is permissible to abbreviate where space is strictly limited, such as in advertising, tables, charts, headlines and subheading.	✓ The desk is about three feet tall. ✓ The desk is approximately three feet tall. ✓ (When not in body copy): The desk is approx. three feet tall.
acre	Acre should always be written in full and never abbreviated.	✓ Acre ✗ AC, Ac or ac, or any other variation
advisor	Spelled with “or” at the end.	✓ advisor ✗ adviser
air-condition 1. air-condition, air-conditioned 2. air conditioner, air conditioning	Always hyphenate when written as a verb and adjective. As a compound noun, always write as two separate words.	✓ air-conditioned ✓ air conditioned ✓ air conditioner, air conditioning ✗ air-conditioner, air-conditioning

all property 1. personal property 2. real property 3. all property	In legal terms, all property can be classified as either personal property or real property. Personal property is movable property that can be subject to ownership, except land. Real property is land and anything attached to the land. Capitalize in title case only when referring to forecasting.	✓ The Colliers total return forecast for All Property in 2027 is 8.4%, with a 2.2% contribution from capital growth.
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The Association of Real Estate License Law Officials ARELLO®	A searchable database to verify the status of real estate practitioners' license or registration. Spell the full name out on first reference and follow with (ARELLO®). Use ARELLO® in all subsequent references.	✓ The Association of Real Estate License Law Officials (ARELLO®) is a searchable database.
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B

build-out	The final construction usually completed to a tenant's specifications. This phrase is always hyphenated. When an adjective is used before, hyphenate only build-out.	✓ Our project management division will supervise your build-out. ✗ They completed an interior-build-out. ✓ The interior build-out is complete.
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build-to-suit	Property developed to suit the tenant. Always hyphenate this phrase.	✓ The build-to-suit developer is marketing industrial in 20-acre parcels.
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building	Spell out building in body copy. Do not capitalize building unless it is part of the proper name of a specific property. Use the abbreviation bldg. for tables, charts, headlines and subheads, not for body copy.	✓ Show the tenant that building. ✓ Show the tenant the Empire State Building. ✗ The tenant is interested in the bldg. lease.
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building classifications 1. Class A 2. Class B 3. Class C	Capitalize both parts. Do not hyphenate Do not put in quotation marks or parentheses.	✓ Class A office space is expensive. They moved into Class B space. Class C spaces are available down the street. ✗ Class-A, class A, Class "A"
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1. Building Owners and Managers Association (BOMA) 2. BOMA	Spell the full name out on first reference and add BOMA in parentheses immediately after. For subsequent references, it is permissible to abbreviate as BOMA.	✓ Building Owners and Managers Association (BOMA) is an industry trade group
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C

cash flow	Always use two words.	✓ cash flow ✗ cash-flow or cashflow
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1. Central Business District (CBD) 2. CBD 3. central business district	Capitalize all three words when referring to a specific geographic area. Follow immediately with CBD in parentheses, only after the first reference. For subsequent references, it is permissible to abbreviate as CBD. Do not capitalize when referring to central business districts in general.	✓ Vacancy in Chicago's Central Business District (CBD) is declining. ✓ In fact, the CBD posted net absorption of 120,000 square feet last quarter. ✓ In any city's central business district, you will find millions of square feet of office space.
1. Certified Commercial Investment Member 2. CCIM Institute 3. CCIM	Spell out this accreditation on first reference, followed by the abbreviation in parentheses (CCIM). It is permissible to use the abbreviation when following someone's name and title.	✓ More than 9,000 professionals in North America have earned the Certified Commercial Investment Member (CCIM) designation. ✓ They earned this designation through the CCIM Institute. ✓ John Smith, Vice President, CCIM
clearspan	Written as one word.	✓ clearspan ✗ clear span
1. column-free 2. column free	This is hyphenated only when used as a compound adjective. Otherwise, write as two words.	✓ That building features a 20,000-square-foot, column-free floor. ✓ The warehouse is column free.
D		
design-build	A method in which a single team works under one contract with the project owner to provide both design and construction services. Always hyphenate this word.	✓ The design-build team includes LEED® Accredited members.
1. dock-high 2. dock height	Dock-high is hyphenated and used as a compound adjective. This term and the phrase dock height are used to describe industrial loading door locations that are at the height of a loading dock.	✓ There are two dock-high doors. ✓ The doors are located at dock height.
E		
EMEA 1. Europe, Middle East and Africa (EMEA) 2. EMEA	Should be referred to as Europe, Middle East and Africa in the first instance with EMEA in parenthesis immediately after. The abbreviation may be used in all subsequent references. Do not use the word the before it.	✓ Our Europe, Middle East and Africa (EMEA) business is headquartered in London. Our clients benefit from our presence in almost every major city across EMEA. ✗ A package came from the EMEA today.
en suite	Not hyphenated, two words.	✓ There are 14 en suite bedrooms.
energy-efficient	This is hyphenated when used as a compound modifier. It is not hyphenated when it is not used as a direct modifier.	✓ The energy-efficient building is available. ✗ An office building could use solar panels to be more energy efficient.

F

floor plan	Write this as two words.	✗ floorplan
floor plate	Write this as two words.	✗ floorplate
footprint	Write this as one word.	✗ foot print
freestanding	Write this as one word.	✗ free standing

G

Grade A	Capitalize both parts. Do not hyphenate. Do not put in quotation marks or parentheses.	✓ Grade A office space is expensive. They moved into Grade B space.
1. grade-level 2. grade level	Hyphenate this term only when using it as a compound adjective.	✓ 12 grade-level doors. ✓ The doors are at grade level.
greenbelt	Write this as one word, lowercase.	✓ A greenbelt surrounds the building.
greenfield	Write this as one word, lowercase.	✓ The investors were seeking a greenfield development.
gross absorption	This refers to the measure of all real estate leasing activity, typically expressed in square feet per quarter. Do not abbreviate or hyphenate this term.	✓ Total gross absorption in the first quarter of the year totaled 17 million square feet.

H

healthcare	Use it as one word, lower-cased except when used as part of a company name.	✓ Investors in the healthcare sector have enjoyed a high yield. ✓ She invested in healthcare real estate. ✓ His client is Lockwood Health Care Systems
high-rise 1. low-rise 2. mid-rise 3. high-rise	Always hyphenate these words.	✓ The high-rise office building is expensive. ✓ We offer a selection of low-, mid- and high-rise buildings. ✓ The rental rates for this high-rise building increased recently.
high-tech	Always hyphenate this word.	✓ We had to convert part of a live manufacturing facility into a high-tech facility within a demanding timeframe.
Hub	Uppercase H as it is a proper noun.	✓ The Hub is Colliers' intranet.

I

in-depth, in depth

Hyphenate this word when used as a modifier before a noun.

✓ She has in-depth knowledge of maps.

1. in-depth

✓ He studied the technology in depth.

2. in depth

Write it as two words when used alone.

J

joint venture

Always written as two words.

✓ This property investment is a joint venture.

✓ They held a joint venture account.

L

1. Landlord

Capitalize in contracts when referring to the specific Landlord in the document.

✓ The Landlord agrees to pay half of build-out costs.

2. landlord

Write with lowercase in general use.

✓ The property has had multiple landlords.

1. Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design (LEED)

On first reference, spell out Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design, following with the acronym in parentheses using the Registered trademark symbol (LEED®). For subsequent references, you may drop the registered trademark symbol.

✓ Example: The Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design (LEED®) Green Building Rating System™ is a third-party certification program. LEED certification provides independent, third-party verification that a building project is environmentally responsible.

2. LEED®

1. LEED® Accredited Professional

On first reference spell out Accredited Professional and Green Associate and include the registered trademark in LEED®. You may drop the registered trademark symbol and use the abbreviation AP and GA for subsequent references.

✓ Colliers University offers more than 40 classes to help our professionals earn their LEED® Accredited Professional or LEED Green Associate certification.

2. LEED® AP

3. LEED® Green Associate

4. LEED® GA

1. LEED® Platinum

Four levels of certification are available to buildings seeking the LEED certification; the rating depends on the building's features.

2. LEED® Gold

3. LEED® Silver

4. LEED® Certified

1. level

This refers to a building floor and is not capitalized unless part of a formal address.

✓ We work on level 12.

2. Level

✓ Stop at Level 22, the restaurant.

license

License is the correct spelling in the United States.

✓ She is a licensed real estate broker.

M

master plan

Always written as two words.

✓ The master plan called for 146 units.

Middle East and North Africa

Refer to as Middle East and North Africa (MENA) in the first instance, then use MENA in subsequent use.

✓ Colliers provides services in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA). Several offices across MENA are available to serve clients.

1. Middle East North Africa (MENA)

2. MENA

million, billion	Where possible, spell out the word in body copy, using lowercase unless at the beginning of a sentence. Use one space before the word. Round decimals to the hundredths (second) place. Always abbreviate to M or B (capitalized) for tables, charts, headlines and subheadings with no space between the number and letter.	✓ \$1 billion, \$1.25 million (body copy) ✓ \$1B, \$1M (Headlines, etc.) ✗ \$1 bn, \$2bn ✗ \$1 m, \$1 Million, \$1 M
mixed-use	Always hyphenate this phrase.	✓ The mixed-use center included a theater, restaurants and 200 residential units. ✗ mixed use or mixeduse
multifamily (with examples) 1. duplex, triplex, quadruplex 2. zero lot line	Write as one word. There are several types of multifamily developments. In the U.S., attached homes are often called a duplex, triplex or quadruplex depending on the number of attached residences in a building. Zero lot line developments place single-family dwellings adjacent by way of an interior side lot line with a zero-foot required setback on one side.	✓ The U.S. multifamily sector is thriving this year. ✓ The development offers several triplex buildings. ✓ Zero lot line multifamily developments are common in urban areas. ✗ Multi-family
multilevel	Write this as one word.	✗ multi-level or multi level
multi-tenant	Always hyphenate this word.	✗ multitenant or multi tenant
N		
net absorption	As this is a commonly used compound noun, do not hyphenate when used as a compound adjective.	✓ She computed the net absorption rate.
O		
off-market, days off market	Hyphenate this phrase when used as a compound modifier.	✓ They purchased an off-market building.
1. off-market 2. off market	Otherwise, use two words.	✓ The building was sold off market.
off-plan, off-the-plan	Always hyphenate this phrase.	✗ off plan or off the plan
1. off-street 2. off street	Hyphenated only when used as a compound modifier. Not hyphenated when used as a simple location (noun).	✓ There is plenty of off-street parking. ✗ Please park off street to avoid a ticket.
ongoing	Write this as one word.	✓ The permitting process is an ongoing concern.
online, offline	Both are written as one word, lowercased, without a hyphen.	✗ on-line, on line, On Line

on-market, days on market 1. on-market 2. days on market	Hyphenate this phrase when used as a compound modifier.	☒ They purchased an on-market building.
	Otherwise, use two words.	☒ The building spent 27 days on market.
on-site, off-site	These are always hyphenated.	☒ There is plenty of on-site parking. ☒ A café is located on-site.
1. open-plan 2. open plan	This word is hyphenated when used as a compound modifier. It is not hyphenated when open only modifies plan.	☒ The space includes 4,000 square feet of open-plan cubicles.
		☒ The office space has an open plan.
owner-occupier	Always hyphenate this phrase.	☒ The owner-occupier is planning to sell.
P		
parking lot, parking space	Always two words. Avoid foreign terms.	☒ parking lot, parking space(s) ☒ parkinglot ☒ carpark or car park
1. per square foot 2. per sq ft 3. PSF 4. per square foot per year (see <i>Numbers & Measurements for additional information.</i>)	For body copy in brochures, reports, proposals, etc, write out per square foot, net per square foot and per square foot per year.	☒ The asking rental rate is \$2.03 per square foot.
	Use PSF or PSF/YR (all caps) where space is limited, such as in charts, tables, advertisements, bulleted lists or incomplete sentences.	☒ Average asking rental rate:\$23.33 PSF/YR. ☒ Midtown's highest average asking rent before the Great Recession was \$92.04 PSF.
pro forma	This is written as two words. It is a document prepared in advance as a model for an expected outcome.	☒ The pro forma property statement shows a drop in income in 2011 due to projected lease expirations.
product types: land, office, hospitality, industrial, multifamily, retail, hotel, mixed-use, residential, technical facilities	Capitalize product types only when used as part of a proper name. Commercial should not be used to refer to office or retail space — use the specific property type term, such as office, retail or industrial instead.	☒ The team leases office space. ☒ The commercial real estate center included several stores.
R		
revenue	This is a singular noun.	☒ Colliers has \$3.3 billion in revenue. ☒ Colliers has \$3.3 billion in revenues.
rezone	Write this as one word.	☒ re-zone
S		
sale-leaseback	Always hyphenate this phrase. It describes a transaction when a business sells its location to an investor but remains in the building after the sale is completed under a lease agreement.	☒ The medical group's broker negotiated a sale-leaseback to an investor.

semi-gross	Always hyphenate this term. A semi-gross lease refers to a scenario wherein a tenant pays base rent along with some of the landlord's proportional costs, e.g. maintenance, repairs, etc.	✓ The advisor helped the client negotiate a reasonable semi-gross lease agreement.
secondary suite	Used to describe a separate living area that is part of a primary dwelling unit. Avoid all other terms to prevent confusion.	✓ Secondary suites include living, bath and kitchen facilities.
skyscraper	Informal term for buildings 12 floors and taller. Written as one word.	
1. Society of Industrial and Office Realtors® 2. SIOR	Spell out Society of Industrial and Office Realtors® on first reference, including the trademark, followed by (SIOR) with parentheses. Use SIOR in subsequent mentions.	✓ The Society of Industrial and Office Realtors® (SIOR) is a professional commercial and industrial real estate association with more than 3,700 members in 45 countries.
square footage	The term [X]-square-foot (singular) is always hyphenated when used as a compound modifier for a noun. For more information, see the Numbers section.	✓ The 25,000-square-foot building is attracting potential tenants.
1. stand alone 2. stand-alone	Hyphenate only when using it as a compound adjective.	✓ This is a stand-alone structure. ✓ The structure was built to stand alone.
startup	Written as one word.	✓ Tech startups are leasing significant space in California.
storefront	Written as one word.	✓ The property offers prominent storefront signage.
story, stories	Story is the correct U.S. spelling. Hyphenate when defined numerically, using numerals.	✓ The building has three stories. The pharmacy is on the first story. ✓ We are leasing a 22-story building.
streetfront	Written as one word.	✓ Streetfront retail space is always in demand.
subdivision	Written as one word.	✗ sub-division
submarket, subsectors	Write these as one word.	✓ Positive rental growth across all subsectors is expected this year.
sublease, sublet	Written as one word.	✗ sub-lease
T		
1. Tenant 2. tenant	Capitalize in contracts when referring to the specific Tenant in the document. Write with lowercase in general use.	✓ The Tenant's signature is required to execute this contract. ✓ Every tenant was pleased with the building's amenities.
test-fit	Always hyphenate this word	
turnkey	Written as one word.	✓ REMS offers clients a turnkey solution for facilities management.

U

1. **urban growth boundary**
2. **UGB**

Spell out on first reference followed by (UGB) in parentheses. Use UGB alone in subsequent references.

- ✓ An urban growth boundary (UGB) is a regional boundary restricting urban development.
- ✓ Every Oregon city is surrounded by a UGB.

V

vendor take-back

Always hyphenate this word.

- ✗ vendor takeback

W

walk-up

Always hyphenate this word.

workforce

Written as one word.

workplace

Written as one word.

workspace

Written as one word.

workstation

Written as one word.

- ✗ work station or work-station

workweek

Written as one word.

- ✗ work space or work-space

Y

1. **year-over-year**
2. **year over year**

Hyphenate this word when used as a modifier.

- ✓ The monthly year-over-year growth rates
- ✓ The amount changed year over year

Z

zonings

Zoning is the set of regulations local governments set to classify allowable uses of land for particular purposes. Examples of zoning classifications include residential, commercial, agricultural, industrial or hotel/hospitality, among other more specific designations

- ✓ Zoned 4(a) General Industrial
- ✗ General Industrial zoned 4(a)



Copy

WORD	RULE	EXAMPLES
and, & (ampersand)	Spell out the word and in most copy. Do not use an ampersand (&) in body copy, unless as part of team, departmental and company names.	✓ She handles advisory and transactions. ✓ The Smith Landlords & Tenants team ✓ Engineering & Design
academic accreditations	List the person's name followed by a comma and then the degree. For multiple degrees within the same field, list only the highest degree. List degrees without periods. When a person has more than one professional designation, use commas to separate them.	✓ Jane Smith, MAI ✓ PhD, CCIM ✓ William Thornton, PhD ✗ John Smith, M.A.I. ✓ George Jetson, CCIM, CRE
addresses	Do not include commas at the ends of lines in an address. The place and zip code (postal code outside the U.S.) should not be divided by a comma. Do not include # before a suite or unit number. Write out the full word on street descriptors in body copy. In charts, tables and headlines, you may abbreviate. When abbreviating, use full stops.	✓ Colliers Los Angeles – Downtown 865 S. Figueroa Street, Suite 3500 Los Angeles, CA 90017 United States (if outside of country) ✓ Rd., St., Ave.

all caps	Do not use all capital letters except for acronyms and initialisms of organizations. Always spell out the name on first use with the acronym or initialism following in parentheses.	✓ Members of the Society of Industrial and Office Realtors (SIOR) gathered today. SIOR events occur annually at this venue. ✓ He is a Certified Commercial Investment Member (CCIM)
abbreviation, initialism, acronym	An abbreviation is a shortened form of the word or phrase. Always use a period, and do not use all caps. An initialism is made up of the first letters of each word in a phrase. They are commonly in all caps. When they're not acronyms, initialisms are read as individual letters. Acronyms are a type of initialism that are pronounced as a word.	✓ Bldg., dept. ✓ CRE, CEO, ROI ✓ HUD, CAM, REIT
dates	When writing the date in full, do not use superscripts like th, rd, st. When writing the date numerically, forward slashes and no spaces should be used. Use MM/DD/YYYY format. Sometimes shortened to M/D/YY. When referring to an era, do not use an apostrophe.	✓ Wednesday, June 14 ✗ Wednesday, June 14th ✓ 06/12/2026, 6/12/26 ✓ 1960s ✗ 1960's
days of the week	Always capitalize the first letter. Only abbreviate days of the week in tables.	✓ Monday, Tuesday ✓ Sun., Mon., Tues., Wed., Thurs., Fri. and Sat.
directions	Capitalize north, south, east and west when they designate a region or part of a proper name. In general, lowercase north, south, northeast, northern, etc., when they indicate compass direction. For nations, lowercase unless they are part of a proper name or are used to designate a politically divided Nation. Abbreviate directions in street addresses. E, N, S, W, NE, SE, SW, etc. Do not use a period unless it falls at the end of a sentence.	✓ North Vancouver, Midwest, Southern accent, West Virginia, East Coast ✓ The site is in the Midwest. ✓ Head south on Yonge Street. ✓ The building is to the west. ✗ Turn North to reach the entrance. ✗ It's at the Southernmost part of the city. ✓ It is in northern Italy. ✓ It is in South Korea. ✓ The Empire State Building is at 20 W 34th St. ✓ Visit the site at 1234 56th St. NE.

e.g. and i.e.	Use e.g. to mean “for example.” Use i.e. to mean “in other words.” The two terms are not interchangeable. In U.S. English, always follow these by a comma and use lowercase with periods. Their phrases are often contained within parentheses.	✓ Colliers offers many practice groups (e.g., transportation, healthcare, retail, hospitality, finance and more). ✓ Colliers’s style is based on the Associated Press (i.e., AP) Stylebook. ✗ eg or ie
electronic “e-” 1. e-book 2. e-business 3. e-commerce 4. email & esports	Most of these are always hyphenated. They are spelled with a lower-case e, except when used at the beginning of a sentence. The terms email and esports are never hyphenated and never capitalized unless used at the beginning of a sentence.	✓ Their e-business was an overnight success. ✗ ecommerce and E-Commerce ✓ E-books take up about 50% of the memory on my laptop. ✓ Please read my email from last week. ✓ Email me the report.
email addresses	The first letter of the person’s first and last names in email addresses are not always capitalized at Colliers. However, it can make the address more readable. Capitalization does not affect delivery. Do not capitalize Colliers.	✓ john.doe@colliers.com ✓ RobertTSchneider@colliers.com
etc. vs. et al. 1. Etc. 2. et al.	Use etc. to complete a list of things. Use et al. to complete a list of people. Only etc. uses a comma before and after when placed midsentence. Both terms require periods, even in the middle of a sentence. When placed at the end of a sentence, use that one period as full-stop punctuation. Both are written in lowercase.	✓ The apartments have many amenities, such as a dishwasher, microwave, updated carpets, etc., and they are leasing at a higher rate. ✓ John Smith et al. agreed to these terms. ✓ The guest list included Sean, Evan et al.
headlines	In a single document, your headlines should be in sentence case. Capitalize the first word and proper nouns only. Do not use all caps or small caps.	✓ Colliers reports solid second quarter results

job titles	Capitalize formal titles when they immediately precede a name. A job title is generally not capitalized if there is an article or pronoun before it. A shorter title may come before the name in some content. In sentences where the name comes first, write titles as follows: Name, Colliers title Region or Name, title Region at Colliers In signatures, write titles as follows: Name Title Region Department Name Colliers	✓ Phil Smith, Colliers vice president of strategic investments EMEA, has been... ✓ I talked to my managing director earlier. ✓ Colliers Vice President Sam Smith
login, log in 1. login 2. log in	Use one word when using as a noun or adjective. Use two words for a verb.	✓ He provided the login number. ✓ She will log in to her platform. ✓ She logged in to the app.
months	Always capitalize the first letter.	✓ September ✓ October ✓ November
seasons	Never capitalize, unless part of a date.	✓ Take-up increased in the summer months. ✓ Summer 2025
time	a.m. and p.m. are written in lower case with periods. Use a space following the number. Use a colon without spaces to separate hours and minutes. If at the top of the hour, just use the initial numeral without :00	✓ 7 p.m. ✗ 7pm, 7PM, 7 PM ✓ 7:15 a.m. ✗ 7 : 15 ✗ 7:00 a.m.
trademarks	Use the trademark symbol ™ or the registered trademark symbol ® on first reference to proper names in body copy if required by the business entity, such as LEED®.	✓ Example: The LEED® Certification trademark is owned by the U.S. Green Building Council.
web addresses	Do not capitalize Colliers in its web address. Do not use www.	✓ colliers.com
website	Written as one word.	✗ Find it on our Web-Site.

Punctuation

WORD	RULE	EXAMPLES
apostrophe	When making an acronym, abbreviation or year plural, add an “s” without an apostrophe.	✓ Four VIPs were at the event. ✓ 1980s
1. apostrophe plural		
2. apostrophe possessive	When using a single letter abbreviation, such as A’s for Oakland Athletics, use an apostrophe, even though this does not denote possession. This is done for clarity so that A’s does not become As. To show possession of one item or concept by another, use apostrophe s (’s) for singular words, and an s followed by an apostrophe (s’) for plural words.	✓ The Oakland A’s are great this year. ✓ He received four A’s and two B’s. ✓ a day’s pay ✓ two weeks’ vacation Note: a hyphenated form may be clearer. E.g., a two-week vacation.
parentheses	When adding supplementary information at the end of a sentence, the final period goes outside the parentheses and there are no spaces between the characters.	✓ (always). ✗ (always) ✗ (always.)
bulleted lists, bullet points	Put a space between the bullet and the first word of each item on the list. Use periods, not semicolons, at the end of each section, whether it’s a full sentence or a phrase. Use parallel construction for each item in the list. Do not use and, commas or semicolons at the end of an item on the list. Introduce the list with a short phrase or sentence.	✓ Bulleted list items should: • Start with the same part of speech for each item. • Use the same verb tense. • Use the same sentence type (e.g., statement, question, exclamation). • Use a phrase, if desired. • Use the same voice (active or passive).

colon, semicolon	Colons can help emphasize a point. Use one space after a colon. Capitalize the first word after a colon only if it is a proper noun or the start of a complete sentence. Use semicolons to indicate a greater separation of thought or information than a comma provides but less than a period indicates. Also, use them for clarity when commas are within the phrases. One space should follow a semicolon. Do not use a semi-colon to introduce bullets. Do not use capital letters after semi-colons unless they are proper nouns. Semi-colons should be used sparingly as complicated sentence structure often lead to muddled and unclear copy.	✓ When prospecting for clients, remember this: People do not want to be bothered at dinner. ✓ The clients are Smith, Jones & Johnson; Webster & Thurston; and Thompson, Woodbridge & Lymon.
comma	One space should follow a comma. Do not place commas before the company's descriptor such as Inc. or Corp. Use a comma for longer introductory phrases or if its omission would slow a reader's comprehension. Do not use a comma if it would divide your sentence into two complete parts. Do not put a comma before the conjunction in a simple series. Put a comma before the concluding conjunction (and, or) in a complex series where any part of the series also includes a conjunction.	✓ apples, pears, bananas ✓ FirstService Corp. is our previous owner. ✗ FirstService, Corp. ✓ On the street below, the curious gathered to learn what happened. ✗ Preparing for his sales pitch, was one of the toughest tasks on his agenda. ✓ EastGroup Properties Inc., is one of our best clients. ✓ The building's amenities include a well-appointed lobby, electronic and key card access, and a conference center.
ellipsis (...)	An ellipsis is constructed with three periods and has a space both before and after. There are no spaces between the periods. It should never be used at the end of a sentence.	✓ It was a pleasure working with Colliers ... we knew we were in safe hands. ✗ Contact our team soon ...

em-dash (long), en dash (medium), hyphen (short)

As wide as the letter M, an em-dash signals an abrupt change. These long dashes are preceded and followed by a space.

As wide as the letter N, the en dash is used in numerical ranges in headlines and tables. Do not use en-dashes in regular copy. There are no spaces before or after an en-dash.

A hyphen joins words for clarity. Only the correctly joined compound words will reflect the intended message. Some word pairs have evolved to be clear without a hyphen. Use a hyphen with “well-combinations” before a noun, but not after.

Use a hyphen in modifiers with three or more words.

- ✓ We are collaborative — and always will be.
- ✗ We are collaborative- and always will be.
- ✓ January 25–27
- ✓ A mixed-use center
- ✓ A third grade teacher
- ✓ Re-covering the book recovered its value.
- ✓ She is a well-known expert.
- ✓ His expertise is well known.
- ✗ He got a two dollar-haircut.
- ✓ Some brokers take a win-at-all-costs approach.

Forward slash, backslash

Often used to separate items in a list or use in place of the word or.

Do not use the forward slash (/) to mean to.

Do not use a backslash.

- ✓ They accept cash and/or credit cards.
- ✓ 2019–20 financial year
- ✗ 2019/20 financial year.
- ✗ 2023\24 financial year

Periods

Use only one space after a period.

- ✓ The property sold. It was a record deal.
- ✗ The value rose. A deal was struck.

Quotation marks

Always use double quotation marks for quotes. Single quotation marks are used for quotes within quotes.

The period and comma always go inside the quotation marks.

The dash, semicolon, question mark and exclamation point go inside the quotation marks when they apply to the quoted matter. They go outside when they apply to the entire sentence.

- ✓ “Upon closing the deal, our client said, ‘Excellent job!’ and we couldn’t be more pleased,” said the broker.
- ✓ John said, “The property is in Phoenix.”
- ✓ The title of the book is, “How shall we live?”
- ✓ Was he serious when he said, “I cannot lower the price?”
- ✓ Did you hear her ask, “Where’s the broker?”



Numbers

WORD	RULE	EXAMPLES
basis points (BPS) 1. basis points 2. BPS	Used to measure fees, spreads and rates in CRE finance. A basis point is equal to 0.01%. A 1% change equals a change of 100 basis points. Spell out in body copy. For subsequent references, and for use in headlines and captions, it is permissible to abbreviate to BPS.	✓ When the fees of a commercial mortgage are at 100 basis points (BPS), that means that they are 1% of the total mortgage value. Colliers' financial experts have tracked BPS averages in this region for two years. ✓ Deal Closes at Record BPS!
billion, million	Where possible, spell out the word in body copy, using lowercase unless at the beginning of a sentence. Use one space before the word. Round decimals to the hundredths (second) place. Always abbreviate to M or B (capitalized) for tables, charts, headlines and subheadings with no space between the number and letter.	✓ \$1 billion, \$1.25 million (body copy) ✓ \$1B, \$1M (Headlines, etc.) ✗ \$1 bn, \$2bn ✗ \$1 m, \$1 Million, \$1 M

commas and numbers	Use a comma to break up numbers greater than 999.	✓ 1,100 ✓ 23,671
capitalization rate or cap rate 1. capitalization rate 2. cap rate	Indicates the rate of return that is expected to be generated on an investment property. Spell out the phrase capitalization rate on first reference. It is not capitalized. In subsequent references, it is acceptable to use the full short form, cap rate. Cap rate quantities always use numerals, not letters. It is always expressed as a percentage.	✓ A building with \$250,000 USD in net operating income and a 10% capitalization rate would be worth \$2.4 million USD. ✓ We sold that building at a 10% cap rate. ✗ We sold that building at a 10 cap rate. This complex is offered at an eight CAP.
capitalization rate or cap rate	A percentage that relates the value of an income-producing property to its future income, expressed as net operating income divided by purchase price. Also known as cap rate.	✓ A building with \$250,000 USD in net operating income and a 10% cap rate would be worth \$2.4 million. ✓ We sold that building at a 10% cap rate.
dates	When writing the date in full, do not use superscripts, such as th, rd, st. or nd. When writing the date numerically, forward slashes and no spaces should be used. Follow the MM/DD/YY format. When writing out the date, place the month before the day's date. When referring to an era, do not use an apostrophe.	✓ Wednesday, June 14 ✓ July 17, 2025 ✓ 6/12/23 ✓ 1960s ✗ Wednesday, 14 June ✗ 10/15/2026 ✗ 1970's
decimals, percentages 1. Decimals 2. Percentages	For decimals and percentages, use numerals (not words). Spelling out the word "percent" and using a percent sign (%) are both permissible. Round decimal points to two places (maximum) for currency, percentages or exact quantities. For any percentage or decimal less than one, use a zero before the decimal point. Do not exceed two decimal places unless necessary.	✓ Rates increased by 4%. ✓ The initiative calls for a 20 percent increase in rental units. ✓ \$6.95 million ✓ Vacancy decreased by 0.5% this year. ✗ The 9.825% cap rate was acceptable.

foot, feet, square feet 1. square foot, per square foot, per sq. ft. 2. square feet 3. sq. ft. 4. SF 5. M SF	Use square foot (no hyphen) as a noun, such as per square foot. Use hyphens when it modifies a noun. Use square feet without a hyphen. Use periods with the preferred body copy abbreviation (sq. ft.), which are used more in blurbs than longer content. SF should be reserved for where is limited, such as research reports, headlines or tables. M SF stands for “million square feet.”	✓ The retail site leased at \$22 per square foot. ✓ The 23,000-square-foot building is located near Main Street. ✓ The space offers 300,000 square feet. ✓ Almost 5,000 square feet are available. ✓ Average office – 2,500 sq. ft. ✓ It's a 3,000-sq.-ft. storefront. ✓ The lot is 3M SF.
fractions	Hyphenate simple fractions when written as words. Convert complex fractions to decimals or percentages when possible. Use numerical figures for precise amounts larger than one, converting to decimals whenever practical.	✓ Three-quarters of tenants agree. ✓ 1.25 ✗ 1-3/4, 13/4 ✓ One and one-quarter ✓ The landlord abated 28% of the rent.
H1, H2	The first (H1) or second (H2) half of a business year. No comma between term and year. Acceptable abbreviation in research reports but avoid using in other documents.	✓ We saw a strong performance in H1 2020. ✓ Challenges arose in H2, 2020.
miles, per square mile	Miles and square miles are commonly used to measure distance and area in the U.S.	✓ The retail outlet is 3 miles from the town center. ✓ Idaho measures 83,642 square miles.
kilometer	One kilometer equals roughly 0.62 miles. Refer to Colliers' Global Style Guide for more information.	
numbers 1-9	Generally, numbers one to nine (with the exception of units) should be spelled out fully. Numbers 10 and above are expressed numerically e.g. 10, 11, 12... Use numerals for ages of things, people, animals and events as well as for units of measure. Numerals are often used in research reports.	✓ This should be completed in three years. ✓ The 5-year-old building sold. ✓ 3 acres or 3-acre site ✗ The thousand-square-foot store

Quarter 1. Quarter (number) 2. Q1 3. quarter over quarter, quarter on quarter	Quarter 1 (for example) should be capitalized when defining the date, and always followed by a number written numerically. Quarter 1 can be abbreviated to Q1 with a capital Q, a numerical 1 and no spaces between. A year can follow it, after a single space. Lowercase quarter over quarter and quarter on quarter. Never hyphenate them.	✓ Quarter 2 ✗ quarter 1, quarter one, 1st quarter or 1 quarter ✓ Q3 ✓ Q2 2027 ✗ 1Q
telephone numbers	In the U.S., phone numbers are commonly spelled with dashes. Some uses may include parenthesis. The country code for the U.S. is +1 International phone numbers should always be written internationally, with spaces and without dashes, periods or parentheses.	✓ 714-499-4133 ✓ (949) 555-1212 ✓ +1 818 556 7140 (for international calls to the U.S.)
time	a.m. and p.m. should be lowercased with periods and a space following the number. Use a colon without spaces to separate hours and minutes. Use a hyphen to separate the start and end times of scheduled items. Do not use spaces or long “em” dashes.	✓ 7 p.m. ✗ 7 PM, 7pm ✓ 7:15 a.m. ✗ 7 : 15 ✓ 11-2 (in lists, headlines, etc.) ✓ 11:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m. (body content)
Time Zones	Use “S” for Standard time when daylight saving is not in effect and “D” for Daylight time when daylight saving is in effect during spring and summer months. No commas or parentheses are used.	✓ 7 p.m. PDT (for Pacific Daylight Time) ✓ 6 a.m. CST (for Central Standard Time) ✓ 6 a.m. CDT (for Central Daylight Time)



Which Word is Correct?

WORD	RULE	EXAMPLES TO FOLLOW
a / an	Use a or an based on the sound of the following word – for vowel sounds, use an, for consonant sounds use a.	• <i>An hour, an egg, an honor, a union, a helicopter, an MBA</i>
accept / except	Accept means to take something offered or to endure a situation. Except means to take exception, exclude or omit.	• <i>He accepted their offer for the building.</i> • <i>All of the offices were empty except one.</i>
affect / effect	Affect (verb) means to influence, impact or change. Effect (verb) means to cause to come into being. Effect (noun) means result.	• <i>This change affects our professionals.</i> • <i>It's hard to effect change. The rent relief will have a positive effect on the market.</i>
among / between / amongst	Use among when you are referring to more than two nouns. Use between when you are referring to just two nouns. Do not use amongst.	• <i>This Manhattan property is among the most expensive in the U.S.</i> • <i>I am choosing between these two options.</i>
assure / ensure / insure	Use assure as a verb meaning to make someone confident of an outcome. Use ensure to mean guarantee. Use insure is used only for references to insurance.	• <i>The broker assured his clients that their deal would close by the end of the month.</i> • <i>The broker's expertise ensures a smooth transaction.</i> • <i>The building is fully insured.</i>

complement / compliment	Complement (noun or verb) means to complete or supplement. Compliment (noun or a verb) means the expression of praise or admiration.	• <i>The roles complement each other.</i> • <i>The client complimented Lisa on her expertise as a broker.</i>
has / have	Use has for a singular noun or pronoun, except for when writing in first person ("I have" instead of "I has"). Always use "has" with Colliers or any other company as they are single entities.	• <i>Colliers has created a research report.</i>
Its / it's	Use its to show possession. Use it's as a contraction of it is. Tip: If the sentence doesn't make sense when you use "it is," use its.	• <i>Colliers has launched its annual campaign.</i> • <i>It's raining today.</i>
that / which	Use that and which when referring to objects. Use who for people. That and which are interchangeable but always use which after a comma.	• <i>We recommend digital display marketing, which reaches more buyers.</i> • <i>They chose the method that won more bids.</i> • <i>She is the broker who closed the deal.</i>
their / there / they're	Their means belonging to them. There denotes location. They're is a contraction of they are.	• <i>Their broker is excellent.</i> • <i>The building is over there.</i> • <i>They're on the way.</i>
theirs / there's	Theirs is a possessive pronoun. Their's is not a word. There's is a contraction for there is.	• <i>The building is theirs.</i> • <i>There's a restaurant around the corner.</i>
U.S. / US / America	U.S. (with periods) is preferred. When ending a sentence with it, the period acts as final sentence punctuation too.	• <i>That Colliers professional leads the U.S. in sales.</i> • <i>She's very successful in the U.S.</i>
your / you're	Your means belonging to you. You're is a contraction of you are.	• <i>We have closed your deal.</i> • <i>You're a wonderful client.</i>

Glossary of Common CRE Terms

TERM	DEFINITION
APAC	Asia-Pacific region
BOMA	Building Owners and Managers Association, and industry trade group
CAGR	compound annual growth rate
CBD	central business district
CCIM	Certified Commercial Investment Member
CPE	Commercial Property Executive
CRE	commercial real estate
CREW	Commercial Real Estate Women
DEI	Diversity, Equity, Inclusion (Not DE&I)
EMEA	Europe, Middle East, and Africa
ERG	employee resource group
LATAM	Latin America
LEED®	Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design
MENA	Middle East and North Africa
MOB	medical office building
SIOR	Society of Industrial and Office Realtors
UGB	Urban growth boundary
ULI	Urban Land Institute
U.S.	United States (U.S. preferred use over US or America)
USGBC	U.S. Green Building Council
WMRE	Wealth Management Real Estate

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